



JEWELLERY FIRST Jean-Christophe Babin, Group CEO, Bvlgari, says that Indians' perception of it being primarily a watch brand will be corrected by opening more jewellery stores

early 2000 along with Shah Rukh Khan at my previous brand [Babin worked with TAG Heuer then]. When we started collaborating, she was an emerging young talent. Nineteen years later she is a well-established strong talent, well beyond India. She is very global. Everyone knows she loves design, and beautiful objects. So, when she endorses high jewellery, she is very credible. For us, Priyanka is a major ambassador the same way Anne Hathaway or Zendaya are. I don't know any other luxury brand with such a roster expressing inclusion, diversity, and different age groups. I think more than any other

luxury brand, we really respect diversity. All our brand ambassadors are women of substance who have extraordinary accomplishments.



Are you focussing more on jewellery or on watches?

We are primarily jewellers... when I say Bvlgari India, my expected take-out is jewellery. However, today it is not exactly that because we have only one jewellery store in Delhi, and until recently all the other stores were watch stores. So, for Indians, the first thing that comes to mind is probably watches. This will be corrected with more stores showcasing jewellery and

'WE'VE TO BRING ROME TO OUR STORES IN INDIA IN TERMS OF DESIGN'

with Priyanka primarily promoting jewellery. Jewellery frames all other categories. If Serpenti is a successful watch, it's because Serpenti is a jewel. Diva is a successful watch because it's a successful jewellery line. We have to bring Rome to our stores in India in terms of design and style; we have to bring jewellery to India. Because without Rome, without jewellery, it's not Bvlgari.



Are we likely to see a Bvlgari resort in India?

Right now, we haven't identified any project in India. The one close to India is in the Maldives... we will start building it next year. We are in Dubai. And yes, I hope that one day we have the chance to open a resort in India. But like in the Maldives and Dubai, we need to find an extraordinary location.



Under your leadership, there has been an increased focus on watches. Will the focus be more on women's or men's watches?

We are equally committed to developing men's and women's watches. During the Geneva Watch Days, we launched more novelties on the masculine side with the Octo Finissimo than we have

on the ladies' side through Serpenti. Eighty per cent of all new innovation is in men's watches. But 70 per cent of all novelties [new launches] are in ladies' watches... We are very strong in jewellery watches, which are typically feminine. Our Octo Finissimo [for men] has also won awards. Till now it was only in titanium. We have launched it in rose gold, which will be more attractive in China, and yellow gold, which will be more attractive in India. The chronograph is very important in India.



How important is e-commerce for you?

The penetration of e-commerce in our business is very heterogeneous according to the country. The Chinese and Americans are prone to buying online. Latin people are more reluctant.

There are some categories that are easier to sell in e-commerce such as fragrances and leather goods. Others, which require a rather omnichannel experience, [are] typically jewellery and watches. You need to feel it. [For] watches and jewellery, the penetration is lower, but it is also true for our competitors. **BT**

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